

Word family: **small / smaller / smallest / smallness**

Base word: small

Comparative: smaller

Superlative: smallest

Related form: smallness

Useful extensions: small-scale, small business, small talk, small change, small print, small-minded

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / related noun forms (相關名詞)

Your sentence:

> “The headphones seemed like a **small escape** from everyday chaos.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **small** does **not** describe physical size.

It means **limited but meaningful in amount or extent**: the headphones offered a **brief, modest escape or moment of relief**, not a complete escape from everyday life.

繁體中文: **程度或範圍不大, 但仍能提供一些實際舒緩或短暫喘息的**

中文翻譯:

> “The headphones seemed like a small escape from everyday chaos.”

「這副耳機就像讓人從日常混亂中得到一個**短暫而有限、但很實在的喘息空間**。」

a small escape = 一點短暫的逃離／喘息; 並非完全擺脫問題, 而是暫時得到一些舒緩

1. **small = object/person/place (物件／人物／地方) not large in physical size — 體積／尺寸較小的**

This is the central physical meaning.

Meaning: Having relatively little physical size, length, height, area, or volume.

Practice 1

> “She lives in a **small** apartment.”

「她住在一個**面積不大的小型單位**。」

Practice 2

> “The headphones come in a **small** case.”

「這副耳機配有一個**尺寸較小的收納盒**。」

small = 在實際尺寸、面積或體積上較小的

2. **small** = amount/number/quantity (數量／金額) not much or many — 數量少的; 金額不大的

Meaning: Limited in number, quantity, or amount.

Practice 3

> “Only a **small** number of customers complained.”

「只有**少量顧客**作出投訴。」

Practice 4

> “We paid a **small** fee for delivery.”

「我們支付了一筆**金額不大的送貨費**。」

small amount/number = 數量、金額或份量較少, 而不是實體尺寸小

3. **small** = degree/extent/effect (程度／範圍／影響) limited rather than large — 程度有限的; 不大的

This is the broad sense used in your original sentence.

Meaning: Limited in degree, extent, or effect.

Practice 5 — Original

> “The headphones seemed like a **small escape** from everyday chaos.”

「這副耳機就像讓人從日常混亂中得到一個**程度有限但很實在的短暫喘息**。」

Practice 6

> “Even a **small** improvement would make the journey more comfortable.”

「即使只是**小幅度的改善**，也會令旅程舒服一點。」

Practice 7

> “The change had only a **small** effect on sales.”

「這項改變對銷售只產生了**程度不大的影響**。」

small = 在程度、範圍或影響上有限，而不是大幅或全面的

4. **small** = importance/problem/mistake (重要性／問題／錯誤) minor and not serious — 輕微的; 不嚴重的; 次要的

Meaning: Not very important, serious, or significant.

Practice 8

> “It was only a **small** mistake.”

「那只是一個**影響不大、並不嚴重的小錯誤**。」

Practice 9

> “We still have a few **small** problems to solve.”

「我們仍有幾個**較輕微、次要的問題**需要解決。」

small problem/mistake = 嚴重程度或重要性較低、影響有限的

This is related to #3, but specifically evaluates **significance/seriousness**.

5. **small** = chance/probability (機會／可能性) low — 機會很低的; 可能性小的

Meaning: Unlikely to happen.

Practice 10

> “There is only a **small** chance of rain.”

「下雨的**可能性很低**。」

Practice 11

> “We have a **small** chance of finishing today.”

「我們今天完成工作的**機會不大**。」

small chance = 某件事發生的可能性較低

Here, Chinese naturally becomes **機會小／可能性低**, not 「小型的機會」.

6. **small = organization/business/group (公司／機構／群體) limited in size or resources — 規模較小的**

Meaning: Having relatively few employees, customers, members, resources, etc.

Practice 12

> “She works for a **small** technology company.”

「她在一家**規模較小的科技公司**工作。」

Practice 13

> “The café is a **small** family business.”

「這間咖啡店是一家**規模不大的家庭企業**。」

small organization/business = 人員、資源、營運範圍或規模較有限的

7. **small = child/young person (兒童) young and little — 年紀小的; 年幼的**

Meaning: Young, especially when describing children.

Practice 14

> “We moved there when I was **small**.”

「我**年紀還很小／年幼時**，我們搬到那裡。」

Practice 15

> “The playground is designed for **small** children.”

「這個遊樂場是為**年紀較小的兒童**設計的。」

small child = 年紀尚小、通常身形也較小的兒童

This develops naturally from physical smallness but often carries an **age** meaning.

8. **small** = voice/sound (聲音) quiet, weak, or lacking force — 微弱的; 小聲的

Meaning: Quiet, soft, or not forceful.

Practice 16

> “She answered in a **small** voice.”

「她用**微弱而小聲的語氣**回答。」

Practice 17

> “A **small** voice came from the back of the room.”

「房間後方傳來一把**很輕、微弱的聲音**。」

small voice = 音量低、力量不足, 往往亦給人膽怯或不自信感覺的聲音

9. **small-scale** = project/business/activity (專案／業務／活動) limited in size or scope — 小規模的

This is an important family extension.

Practice 18

> “The company began with a **small-scale** trial.”

「公司先進行了一次**規模有限的小型試驗**。」

Practice 19

> “They run a **small-scale** farming operation.”

「他們經營一個**規模較小的農業業務**。」

small-scale = 在參與人數、資金、地區或活動範圍方面規模有限的

10. **small business** (企業類型) — 小型企業

Meaning: A business with relatively limited staff, revenue, or operational scale.

Practice 20

> “The software was designed for **small businesses**.”

「這套軟件是為**小型企業**設計的。」

Practice 21

> “Many **small businesses** rely on local customers.”

「很多**小型企業**依靠本地顧客。」

small business = 人員、收入或營運規模相對有限的企業

The formal/legal definition of “small business” varies by jurisdiction, but the general vocabulary sense is stable.

11. **small talk** = light, informal conversation about unimportant topics — 閒聊; 寒暄

This is a very important family extension.

Meaning: Polite, casual conversation about ordinary subjects rather than serious or personal matters.

Practice 22

> “We made **small talk** while waiting for the meeting to begin.”

「我們等候會議開始時隨意**寒暄閒聊**。」

Practice 23

> “He finds **small talk** with strangers difficult.”

「他覺得跟陌生人作一般的**閒聊寒暄**很困難。」

small talk = 關於天氣、日常生活等輕鬆話題的簡短社交談話, 而非深入討論

Here, **small** means something like **not serious or substantial**, not physically small.

12. **small change** = low-value coins / insignificant amount of money — 零錢; 小額金錢

Practice 24

> “Do you have any **small change** for the parking meter?”

「你有沒有一些**零錢**可以付停車費？」

Practice 25

> “For a large company, that amount is **small change**.”

「對一家大型公司來說, 那筆錢只是**微不足道的小額金錢**。」

small change = 面值較小的硬幣; 亦可比喻金額小得不值得特別在意

13. **small print**(合約／廣告) — 小字條款; 容易被忽略的重要細節

Especially British English; American English often uses **fine print**.

Meaning: Important conditions or restrictions printed in very small text, especially in contracts or advertisements.

Practice 26

> “Always read the **small print** before signing a contract.”

「簽合約前一定要閱讀**細小字體**列出的條款和限制。」

Practice 27

> “The offer looked good until I read the **small print**.”

「這項優惠本來看起來很好, 直到我看到那些**容易被忽略的細節條款**。」

****small print = 以細小字體列出的條款、限制或重要細節****

14. ****small-minded = person/attitude (人／態度) narrow, petty, intolerant — 心胸狹窄的; 斤斤計較的****

A useful family extension.

****Meaning:**** Unwilling to consider ideas different from one's own, or overly concerned with petty matters.

Practice 28

> “It would be ****small-minded**** to reject the idea simply because it came from a competitor.”

「只因為這個構思來自競爭對手便拒絕它, 是很****心胸狹窄的****。」

Practice 29

> “She disliked the ****small-minded**** gossip in the office.”

「她不喜歡辦公室裡那些****心胸狹窄、斤斤計較式的閒言閒語****。」

****small-minded = 思想狹窄、不願接受不同觀點或過度計較小事的****

This is not simply “having a small mind” literally.

15. ****smallness = state/quality of being small — 小; 微小程度; 規模小****

Practice 30

> “The ****smallness**** of the room made it difficult to fit all the furniture.”

「房間****面積太小****, 很難放下所有家具。」

Practice 31

> “The ****smallness**** of the sample limits the study.”

「樣本****數量太少****限制了這項研究。」

****smallness = 在尺寸、數量、規模或程度上較小的狀態****

Important distinction: **small vs little**

They overlap strongly, but there are useful differences.

**small**

more neutral and objective:

> “a small apartment”

「面積較小的單位」

**little**

can also mean small, but often adds emotion, affection, criticism, or the idea of “not much.”

> “a lovely little café”

「一間可愛的小咖啡店」

> “I have little time.”

「我幾乎沒有時間。」

So ****little**** has several grammatical and emotional uses that ****small**** does not.

Important distinction: **small vs short**

**small**

= limited size, amount, or extent

**short**

= limited length, height, or duration

Compare:

> “a small room”

> = 面積小的房間

> “a short meeting”

> = 時間短的會議

We normally would not say *a small meeting* if we simply mean it lasted only ten minutes. **Small meeting** would more naturally mean **few participants**.

Important distinction: **small vs minor**

small

Broad everyday word.

> “a small problem”

minor

More specifically means **not serious or important**, often more formal.

> “a minor problem”

Both can mean:

「小問題／輕微問題」

But **minor** does not normally describe physical size:

> “a small box” 

> “a minor box” 

Important distinction: **small vs slight**

small

can describe size, amount, degree, etc.

slight

usually describes a **very limited degree or difference**.

> “a slight improvement”

「輕微改善」

> “a small improvement”

「小幅改善」

Slight often emphasizes that the change is barely noticeable.

Important distinction: a small escape vs an escape

In your sentence:

> “The headphones seemed like **a small escape** from everyday chaos.”

The adjective **small** is important.

It tells us the headphones did **not**:

- * solve all the person's problems;
- * remove them permanently from stressful life;
- * completely eliminate everyday chaos.

Instead, they provided:

- * a little peace;
- * temporary relief;
- * a brief psychological break;
- * a limited sense of separation from stress.

So **a small escape** is naturally:

「短暫的小小喘息／片刻抽離」

rather than literally:

「細小的逃走」 ❌

Family-extension note

Following our Golden Manual, these are especially useful:

- * **small-scale** = 小規模的
- * **small business** = 小型企業
- * **small talk** = 寒暄／閒聊
- * **small change** = 零錢；微不足道的小額金錢
- * **small print** = 小字條款
- * **small-minded** = 心胸狹窄的
- * **small voice** = 微弱、小聲的聲音
- * **small chance** = 很低的可能性

One common expression also worth recognizing:

****no small achievement / no small matter****

Here, ****no small**** means ****significant / considerable****, not “not tiny” literally.

> “Finishing the project in two weeks was ****no small achievement****.”

「兩星期內完成專案是****相當了不起、絕非小事的成就****。」

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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small — physical size	在實際尺寸、面積或體積上較小的
small — amount/number	數量、金額或份量較少的
small — degree/extent	在程度、範圍或影響上有限，而不是大幅或全面的
small — importance/problem	嚴重程度或重要性較低、影響有限的
small chance	某件事發生的可能性較低的
small business/group	人員、資源或營運規模相對有限的
small child	年紀尚小、通常身形亦較小的兒童
small voice	音量較低、力量微弱，常帶膽怯感的聲音
small-scale	在人數、資金或活動範圍方面規模有限的
small talk	關於普通輕鬆話題的簡短社交寒暄，而非深入討論
small change	小面值零錢；亦可指微不足道的小額金錢
small print	以細小字體列出的條款、限制或容易被忽略的細節
small-minded	思想狹窄、不願接受不同觀點或過度計較小事的
smallness	在尺寸、數量、規模或程度上較小的狀態

| **no small + noun** | 強調某事相當重要、困難或值得重視, 絕非小事 |

For your original sentence

> “The headphones seemed like a **small escape** from everyday chaos.”

The exact meaning is:

small = 程度和範圍有限, 但仍具有實際價值的

So:

a small escape = 從日常壓力和混亂中得到的一點短暫喘息／片刻抽離

The headphones did not remove everyday chaos completely; they gave the listener **a little private space and temporary relief from it**.